

Creamy Tomato Basil Pasta

A comforting Italian-inspired pasta recipe • Serves 4 • Preparation: 15 min • Cooking: 25 min

Cuisine Italian	Diet Vegetarian	Difficulty Easy	Total Time 40 minutes
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About This Recipe

Creamy Tomato Basil Pasta combines al dente pasta with a rich tomato sauce, garlic, fresh basil, and a smooth creamy finish. It is designed as a simple weeknight meal but can also be served as a comforting dinner for guests.

Ingredients

Ingredient	Quantity
Penne or rigatoni pasta	400 g
Olive oil	2 tablespoons
Garlic, finely chopped	4 cloves
Onion, finely diced	1 medium
Crushed tomatoes	400 g
Tomato paste	2 tablespoons
Heavy cream	150 ml
Fresh basil leaves	1 large handful
Parmesan cheese, grated	50 g
Salt	1 teaspoon, or to taste
Black pepper	½ teaspoon
Red pepper flakes	¼ teaspoon (optional)

Preparation

1. Bring a large pot of salted water to a boil. Cook the pasta according to the package directions until al dente. Reserve about 1 cup of pasta water, then drain.
2. Heat olive oil in a large skillet over medium heat. Add the onion and cook for 3–4 minutes until softened. Add garlic and cook for another 30 seconds.
3. Stir in the tomato paste and crushed tomatoes. Season with salt, black pepper, and red pepper flakes. Simmer for 8–10 minutes.

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Cooking Instructions & Serving Guide

Continue Cooking

4. Reduce the heat to low and stir in the heavy cream. Simmer gently for 2–3 minutes; do not let the sauce boil rapidly.
5. Add the drained pasta to the skillet and toss until evenly coated. If the sauce is too thick, add reserved pasta water one tablespoon at a time until the desired consistency is reached.
6. Turn off the heat. Add grated Parmesan and most of the fresh basil. Toss again and taste for seasoning.
7. Serve immediately with the remaining basil and an extra sprinkle of Parmesan.

Chef's Tips

- Cook the pasta slightly under the package's maximum cooking time so it finishes perfectly in the sauce.
- Reserve pasta water before draining; its starch helps loosen and emulsify the sauce.
- Use fresh basil near the end of cooking to preserve its aroma and flavor.
- For a richer sauce, add an extra tablespoon of Parmesan just before serving.
- For a lighter version, replace part of the cream with milk.

Optional Variations

Variation	Suggested Change
Spicy	Increase red pepper flakes or add chopped fresh chili.
Protein-rich	Add grilled chicken, prawns, or white beans.
Vegan	Use plant-based cream and dairy-free Parmesan.
Extra vegetables	Add spinach, mushrooms, zucchini, or roasted bell peppers.

Recipe Summary

Servings	4
Preparation time	15 minutes
Cooking time	25 minutes
Total time	40 minutes
Main ingredients	Pasta, tomato, cream, basil, Parmesan
Best served	Hot, immediately after preparation

Storage: Refrigerate leftovers in an airtight container for up to 3 days. Reheat gently with a splash of water or milk to loosen the sauce.